

Lonely at THE TOP

The Congress alienates its traditional secular allies and ends up strengthening an Opposition in disarray

By Priya Sahgal

Ironically, it was RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav who first warned the Congress not to be too arrogant about its new-found mandate. Speaking in Parliament barely a month after the results were announced, he cautioned: "Delhi is a *maya nagri* (city of illusions) and those who come here don't rule forever". Two months later, the Congress led-Government may not have achieved much of its hundred-day agenda. But it has achieved one thing: creating an unprecedented unity among its former allies and the Opposition. It has also set a notorious precedent of having to send back a bill at the introductory stage. That's what happened to the Judges (Declaration of Assets and Liabilities) Bill, 2009, where two of its own MPs joined the Opposition against it.

This act-first-explain-later attitude also saw the UPA allies more in sync with the sentiments of the Opposition rather than the treasury benches. In the case of the Indo-Pak joint statement from Sharm el-Sheikh, no ally joined the Congress in defending the prime minister. "It was the prime minister who had to explain, not us," said a minister from the Trinamool Congress. The allies have been silent on other issues too, like the equally controversial suggestion to set up a central development authority for Bundelkhand or the mishandling of its Pakistan policy over the release of Hafiz Saeed, the

Jamaat-ud-Dawa chief. On the last issue, the RJD, SP and the Left joined the NDA in a walkout.

When asked why the Government had not tried to build a consensus before introducing the Judges Bill, a Union minister simply said, "We did not expect opposition on something as innocuous as this." It is this kind of unilateral decision-making that is upsetting the UPA allies. Pawan Kumar Bansal, the soft-spoken parliamentary affairs minister lacks Ghulam Nabi Azad's networking skills that are a vital part of this portfolio. Of the two ministers of state, though V. Narayan- asamy is a good backroom manager, he lacks the seniority necessary to hammer out strategic deals with Opposition stalwarts while Prithviraj Chavan already has a full plate managing his other portfolios. Congress chief whips in both Houses, P.J. Kurien in the Rajya Sabha and Pawan Singh Ghatowar in the Lok Sabha, too lack the finesse to work out cross party co-ordination on the floor of the House. They could not even inspire their own MPs to attend. Finally, it was a Sonia Gandhi diktat on attendance that filled the treasury benches.

Even Sis Ram Ola as the deputy leader of the Lok Sabha hardly inspires confidence, both within his party and across the floor of the House. After all he is the man who was ostensibly dropped from Manmohan Singh's Cabinet in UPA-II because of his lacklustre performance during the first round. It is left to Pranab Mukherjee as the leader of the House to step in

SIPRA DAS



whenever there is a crisis. During the debate on the Indo-Pak joint statement, the Congress first fielded a lightweight, P.C. Chacko. It was only when Mukherjee spoke that there was some modicum of damage control.

Not surprising then whenever there is a crisis, the party's troubleshooter Ahmed Patel can be seen shuttling from Bansal's room to Mukherjee's chamber. The Congress is, therefore, unable to capitalise on the disarray in the BJP which is too busy sorting its own affairs to act as a strident Opposition. On the contrary it has given the BJP added strength by alienating some of its own secular allies, like Lalu and Mulayam Singh Yadav with its 'don't care' attitude. Lalu is sulking over the fact that the Congress